

is recorded onto 3-inch DVD discs, which can then be played directly (after “finalisation”) on PCs and DVD players, but there are some limitations.

DVD-Rs are write-once discs, and can be played on almost all (except some of the oldest) DVD players. DVD-RW are rewriteable discs that can be recorded over many times. Similar to DVD-Rs, they are compatible with most DVD players. The other DVD format for rewriteable discs, DVD-RAM, is also available in camcorders. However, DVD-RAM discs will not play on anything other than a compatible DVD-RAM player, limiting its universal portability. In using any DVD-based camcorder, ensure compatibility with your PC and your DVD players.

Some camcorders offer hard disk-based storage media. The limitation here was that the storage media was fixed. Unlike DVDs and tape, which you can swap for fresh blank ones, there was an upper limit on the amount of footage you could store on the hard disk. You would then need to transfer the data to some other medium—PC hard disk, external tape, etc., before you could continue with your recording. Manufacturers, in response to these problems, have started incorporating higher capacities and the ability to swap drives once they get full.

One other limitation with hard disk-based storage is that the media is a more “volatile” storage medium compared to tape and DVDs—accidental knocks can potentially damage the hard disk and corrupt the data. The increasing robustness of hard disk construction can alleviate this risk to some extent.

2.1.3. Flash

Flash memory drives have sufficiently increased in storage capacities to become serious contenders. These are available in formats such as the Secure Digital (SD) Card, Memory Stick, Memory Stick Pro, and others. Pure Flash-based camcorders are extremely compact, and can record up to one hour of high-quality MPEG-2 video, dependant, of course, on the memory capacity of the card.